my years with the union, I've never seen any grudges carried deliberately out of the conference room. Any suffering careerwise definitely isn't retaliatory, although there are a lot of people involved in making a motion picture, and you become typecast in their minds on the basis of what they know about you off the screen. They stop thinking of you as an actor. The image they have of you isn't associated with your last role, but with the guy who sat across the conference table, beefing. And that's death! You develop a sort of aura. People even forget in time how you came to have it. Your name just doesn't come up when parts are being discussed."

I wasn't unhappy, though. In Hollywood, I'd found more than I'd ever expected life to give me. For many, many reasons, these were very happy years for Nancy and me. My income from General Electric had enabled us to build a dream home overlooking the Pacific Ocean that GE stuffed with every imaginable electric gadget. We also bought a 350-acre ranch in the Santa Monica Mountains north of Los Angeles that we loved. And, although GE kept me on the road a lot, there were long stretches of my life during that period when my daily routine focused entirely on my family, our ranch, and a horse.

To my mind, nothing compares with the kinship between man and animal you find on the back of a horse. I'm not sure what it is, but there you are, in charge of an animal with more muscle in its neck than you have in your whole body. From the minute the horse takes its first step, every muscle in your own body begins to respond to it; how much of the experience is physical and how much is mental, I don't know, but there's no better place for me to think than on the top of a horse.

As you rock along a trail to the sound of the hooves and the squeak of leather, with the sun on your head and the smell of the horse and your saddle and the trees around